



**DEPARTMENT OF THE AIR FORCE
DEPARTMENT OF MECHANICAL ENGINEERING
USAF ACADEMY, COLORADO**

22 Oct 2025

Colonel Cory A. Cooper, PhD, USAF
Permanent Professor and Head
Department of Mechanical Engineering
2354 Fairchild Drive, STE 6L-159
United States Air Force Academy, CO 80840

Dear Colleague,

On behalf of the United States Air Force Academy's Dean of the Faculty, I am inviting applications from qualified officers interested in serving as the Permanent Professor and Head of the Department of Astronautics at the United States Air Force Academy (USAFA), Colorado.

I am chair of an ad hoc search committee that will evaluate candidates for this position. Your records show that you may be qualified to apply. We invite you to consider the information provided below on the unique role of a Permanent Professor along with the responsibilities and qualifications for the Permanent Professor and Head of the Department of Astronautics.

The Permanent Professor

Permanent Professors ensure the integration, continuity, and evolution of the Academy's instructional program by providing senior institutional leadership, strategic direction, organizational stability, and oversight of the course of instruction. Their special terms of service reflect the demands of maintaining the highest quality academic, military, athletic, and leadership programs at a military service academy, which is also an accredited institution of higher learning, and their long tenures guide the institution through the turbulence caused by rapid rotational assignments.

By law, USAFA is authorized 25 Permanent Professors; they are appointed by the President, with the advice and consent of the Senate. Permanent Professors, other than the Dean of the Faculty (a brigadier general), hold the grade of colonel. They remain part of the Regular Air Force or Space Force, but they are not on the active duty list. A Permanent Professor may remain on active duty until age 64 with the approval of the Secretary of the Air Force. Upon retirement, any Permanent Professor whose service in that role has been long and distinguished may be retired in the grade of brigadier general, without the pay of that grade. Otherwise, Permanent Professors have no opportunity to promote beyond the grade of colonel. Likewise, it is extraordinarily rare to return to the line of the Air Force or Space Force. For all these reasons, to become a Permanent Professor is to embark on a new career, and not just a new assignment. (See USAFAI 36-3532 – *Permanent Professors* for more details, provisions, and Title 10 U.S. Code references.)

The Permanent Professor and Head of the Department of Astronautics leads 35 military and civilian faculty members, teaching undergraduate courses to more than 1,400 cadets annually. The Department of Astronautics administers the Astronautical Engineering major and co-administers the Systems Engineering major and Space Warfighting minor. The Permanent Professor also manages a dynamic \$6M research lab and \$65M worth of assets, including the on-orbit FalconSat program funded by Air Force Space Command, AFRL, and other DoD organizations.

Permanent Professors serve on USAFA's senior academic council that establishes institutional policies and oversees curricular changes and supports the Department of the Air Force by creating and promoting faculty and cadet research projects in support of national priorities. In addition, Permanent Professors take part in the total course of instruction across USAFA, advising and otherwise serving the broader faculty, Dean, and Superintendent.

Qualifications

To be appointed Permanent Professor, an officer must have an outstanding military record and hold the grade of Lieutenant Colonel or higher. Officers with a line number for Lieutenant Colonel may apply. Candidates will have a doctorate degree and demonstrated excellence as an Airman- and/or Guardian-scholar.

The most qualified candidates will have the following attributes and experiences:

- A dissertation-based Doctorate degree from an accredited in-residence program
 - Applicants who are on track to finish their degrees in the next couple of years may also apply
- Academic expertise in astronautical, aeronautical, aerospace, mechanical, or electrical engineering, or a closely related discipline with a focus on astronautical engineering topics
 - Possess knowledge of related scholarly works
 - Produced research/publications in peer-reviewed conferences, journals, or other publications in your area of expertise
- Familiarity with the ABET accreditation process
- Experience leading organizations
- Ability to communicate with senior leaders on astronautical engineering and space-relevant curricular and research matters
- Experience as an educator, particularly at the undergraduate level
- Experience developing engineering curriculum
- Experience integrating curriculum and/or developmental experiences across multiple organizations

Application Process

We are conducting a multi-phase application process. This announcement invites the submission of a brief “mini application” that will be used to identify candidates for a follow-up. Those identified for a follow-up will then be asked to submit a full application package in late November. The search committee will identify finalists from this second submission and invite these finalists for in-person interviews in mid-January. Following interviews, a candidate will be recommended to the USAFA Superintendent and, on approval, nominated for appointment.

If you are interested in and feel you are qualified for the role of Permanent Professor and Head of the Department of Astronautics as described above, we invite you to submit a mini application package consisting of:

- A brief cover letter containing your statement of interest in this position and a summary of your relevant qualifications (maximum 2 pages)
 - Articulate why your degree/experience is appropriate for this position
- An abbreviated curriculum vitae (CV) tailored to the qualifications of the Permanent Professor and Head of the Department of Astronautics (maximum 3 pages)
- Unofficial copies of your graduate school transcripts
- A current SURF
- Your last 5 OPRs, OPBs or TRs

Please compile the mini application items into a single, well-organized, flat pdf file (i.e., not a portfolio), in the format of: *last_first_DFAS_round_1.pdf*, and send it to me via email at cory.cooper@afacademy.af.edu. Your mini application must be received no later than 1700hrs MT, 21 November 2025. I will reply to confirm receipt.

Please note that submission of the mini application is an expression of interest and not a commitment to assignment availability. Prior to completion of the search process, we will coordinate with the nominee’s current command and the Air Force Personnel Center/Enterprise Talent Management Office on assignment timing and availability.

If you need additional information or have any questions, please feel free to contact me via the email above or by phone at 719-333-6266 (DSN 333). In the meantime, to help ensure the search committee has notified all potentially qualified applicants, please acknowledge receipt of this letter via an email reply and indicate whether you intend to apply for the position. We hope you decide to apply, and we look forward to learning about your Air Force/Space Force career and aspirations.

Sincerely,

COOPER.CORY
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 CORY A. COOPER, PhD, Colonel, USAF

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